

The *State of Crime in Florida's Top Five Colleges* project utilizes the Campus Safety and Security dataset provided by the Department of Education (DoE) to visualize and analyze common crimes in five college campuses in Florida. These colleges were chosen because they had the highest enrollment in the state (DoE, 2025).

Data was downloaded from source as a CSV and connected to Tableau desktop. Each row of the CSV was a statistical observation in the form of crime tallies at a specific institution in a specific year. Rape, fondling, incest, statutory rape, aggravated assault, and burglary were the statistical parameters chosen for this project. They were used to create three figures: A line chart describing the trend of sexual offenses over time, a treemap highlighting the volume of aggravated assault at each school, and a lollipop chart illustrating the frequency of burglary at each institution.

The line chart describes Sexual Misconduct at Florida's Top 5 Universities from 2019 to 2023. For visual simplicity, all forms of sexual misconduct (rape, fondling, incest and statutory rape) were grouped together as sexual assault using the SUM tool. These measures differ in the specific form in which assault occurred: whereas rape is the penetration of the vagina or anus, fondling refers to all touching of private body parts of another unwilling person for the purpose of sexual gratification. Statutory rape is a specific designation for non-forcible sexual intercourse with a person who is under the statutory age of consent. Incest is the sexual intercourse between two individuals where marriage is illegal by law (DoE, 2025). Purdum with the New York Times reported that sexual assault became increasingly prevalent on college campuses, a situation worsened by colleges refusing to escalate reported cases (Purdum, 1988). Grogger's (1991) rational crime model

notes that certainty of crime is a far better deterrent compared to the severity of punishment. The underreporting phenomenon drives low certainty of punishment, which leaves less expected cost of crime, possibly leading to more sexual assault. More recently, Fenda et al (2016) reviews that sexual assault not only remains to be prevalent on college campuses but vary widely across colleges. Some schools pay less attention to non-white non-heterosexual female victims. Thus, differing identity compositions may explain the discrepancy in sex offense reporting rather than a difference in frequency of occurrence. Nonetheless, sex crime in Florida is less severe than the national trend, with most schools between 20-40 below the national average of 74 per 100,000 (NCES, 2023).

The treemap describes the scale of aggravated assault at each campus. Aggravated assault is an attack on another person. Aggravated assault is a felony form of assault involving the possession of a weapon (DoE, 2025). The size of each box depends on a measure originating from the aggravated assault column of the CSV file, rated to a per 100,000 basis and averaged over the span of 5 years. It is noteworthy that the University of Florida (Florida, UF) had more than five times more aggravated assault than the institution with the second most cases of aggravated assault. This is in part a product of its central location in Gainesville, which was notably known for a homelessness and violent crime crisis in the observed time interval (see Figure 1)(Lunn, 2021). Aggravated assault is generally the least common of the three crimes studied in terms of national averages, with only about 15 per 100,000 students (NCES, 2016). This highlights FU's violence problem: aggravated assault is doubly as common in Florida. Indeed, the availability of comparable data demonstrated to Gainesville authorities a need to address the issue. Multiple

measures were passed to decrease the rate of violent crime, coming to a noticeable decrease in violent crime as in 2025 (Tuberville 2026).

Lastly, The lollipop chart describes the average level of burglary on college campuses. Burglary is the unlawful entry of a structure to with criminal intent (DoE). Campuses are dense, have predictable resident schedules, as well as high yearly turnover(Soldato, 2025). Each of these create a lower probability for criminals to be convicted, decreasing certainty of crime. Location also matters: universities such as FIU and UCF on the edge of population centers exhibited the lowest level of burglaries, colleges like Florida and FSU which are the center local population density experienced more than double the amount of burglary compared to the next highest institution (see Figure 1). Despite the prevalence of assault in UF and FSU, Florida schools still have significantly lower burglary rates than the national average of 52.3 per 100,000. The difference suggests that the State of Florida has relatively less property crime compared to the US.

The data demonstrates that the rate of crime is generally higher in schools located in population centers, especially specialized college towns. Rate of sexual misconduct reporting also depends on institutional culture beyond the actual rate of occurrence, highlighting a need for increased education on sexual violence. Ultimately, Florida's universities are generally safer in most aspects to national standards, suggesting a general level of success in campus security measures despite drastic internal differences.

Appendix

References

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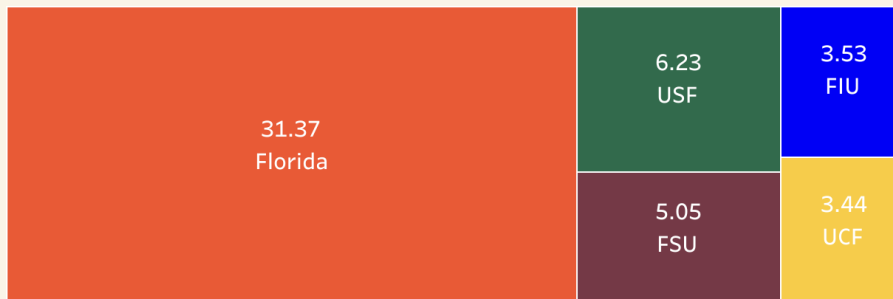
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Common Crimes in Florida's University Campuses

Average Aggravated Assaults* 2019-2023

Highlight an Institution
No items highlighted

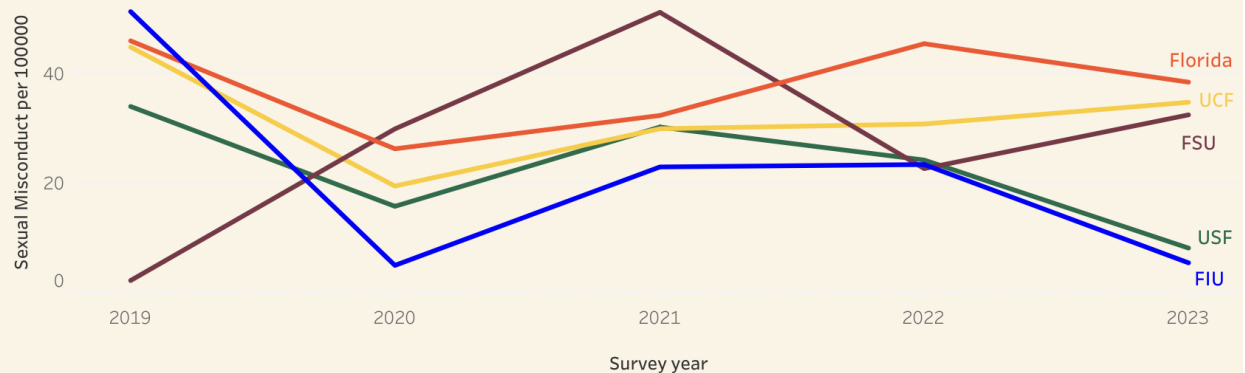


Common crimes in Florida's top five university campuses by enrollment include **aggravated assault**, **sexual misconduct**, and **burglary**.

Data and definitions sourced from: US Department of Education Office of Postsecondary Education Campus Safety and Security.
<https://ope.ed.gov/campussafety/#/>

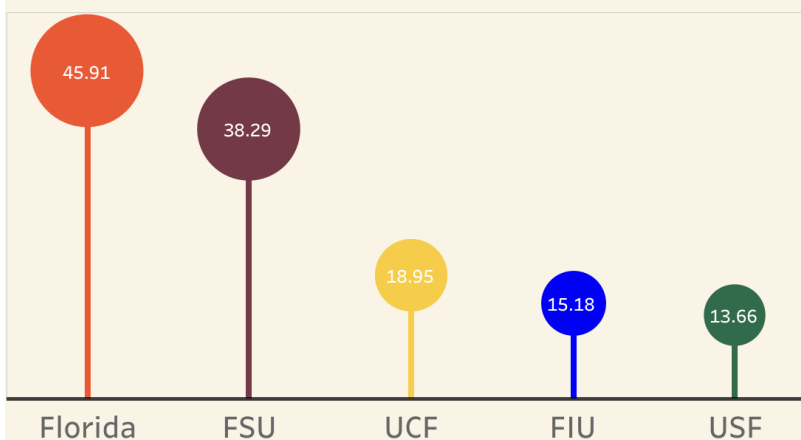
*Aggravated assault is an unlawful attack on another person with the intention of serious bodily harm, aggravated by the possession of a weapon or other means likely leading to death.

Sexual Offenses* 2019-2023



*Sexual misconduct aggregates acts of rape, fondling, and incest committed on campuses.

Average Burglary* 2019-2023



All measures are standardized to a per 100,000 student basis. This allows for the statistical tallies to be comparable without being affected by the difference in the number of students between schools. This standard allows these statistics to be compared nationally or internationally as well.

The University of Florida (Florida) can be considered the most dangerous of these schools, especially in instances of aggravated assault and sex crimes.

Florida State (FSU) experienced an uptick in sex crimes during the coronavirus pandemic, and follows closely to Florida in average burglary crimes

Florida International University (FIU) and **University of South Florida (USF)** are among the safest in all categories, w..

*Burglary is the unlawful entry for the purposes of felony or theft, without causing violence.

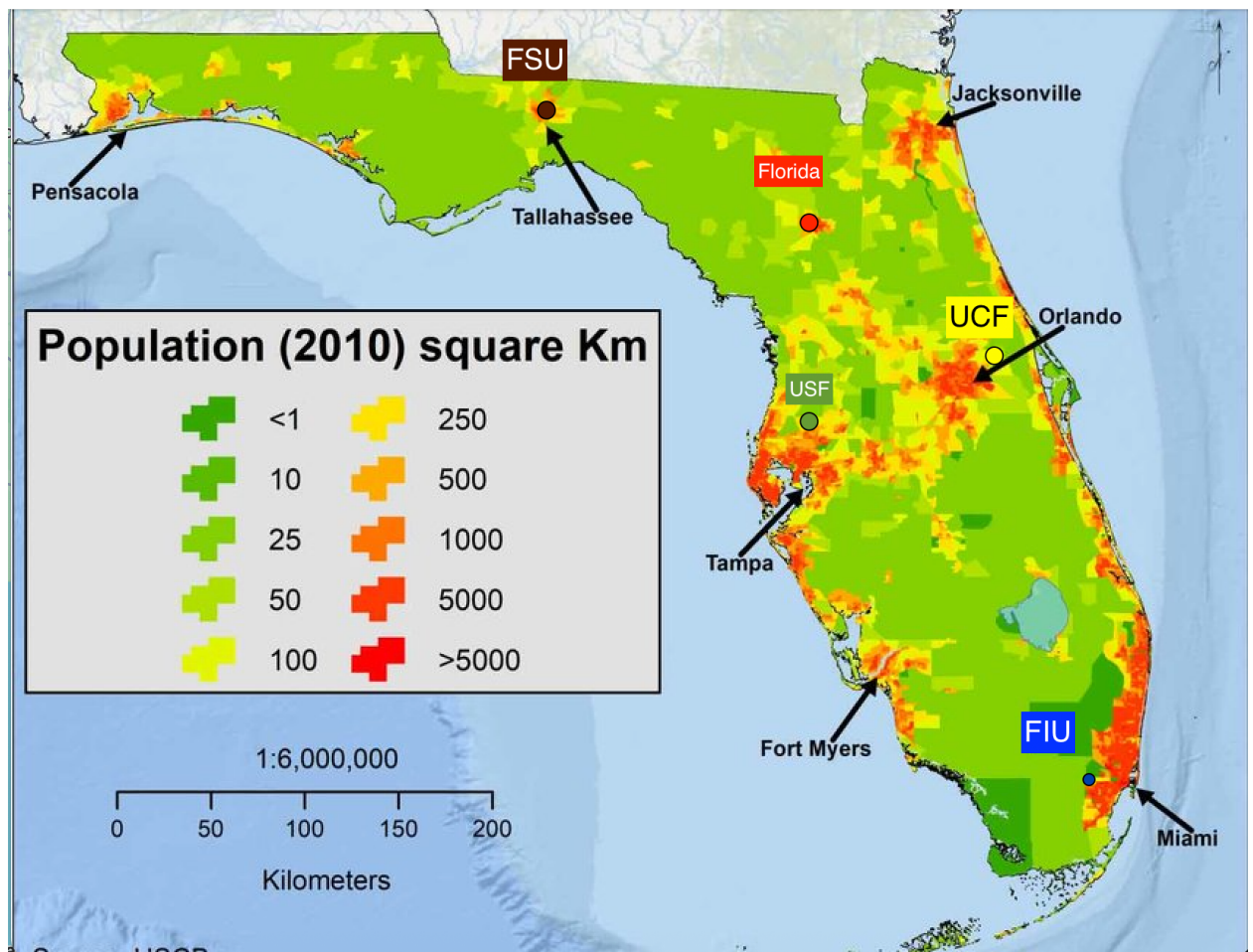


Figure 1 Florida's Five Largest Universities Population Density of Florida (2010 US Census)